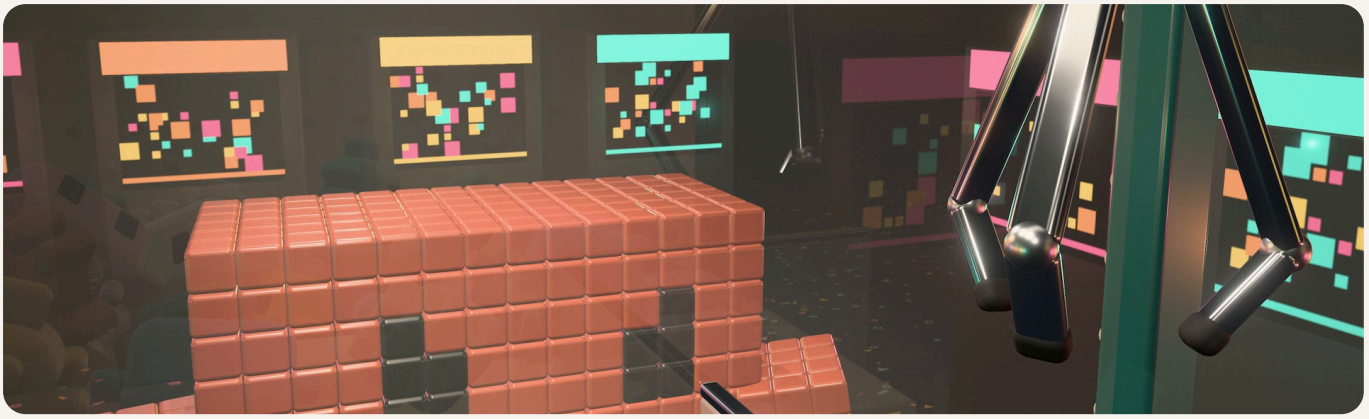
CHARACTER FILM / 20 S / 16:9 / 60 FPS

Three coins. One plush.

In a night arcade the Claude mascot stands on a step stool at a claw machine with three pixel coins. Try one: the weak grip drops the plush. Try two: it slips onto the chute rail, teeters, tumbles back, and the mascot leans in and bonks its forehead on the glass. Try three, holding its breath: THUNK. It hops down, pulls out the plush version of itself and hugs it, and the plush slowly blinks at us. Every frame is code written by Claude Opus 5.5 from the prompt on page 2.



20 s	60 fps	1920x1080	1 file	280	7 + 3
STORY, HELD ENDING	1200 FRAMES	16:9, RENDERED AT 2X	HTML, THREE.JS	WORDS OF PROMPT	FOLLOW-UPS, PICTURE + SOUND



0.40 S
COIN IN, THE MACHINE WAKES



3.80 S
TRY 1: THE WEAK GRIP



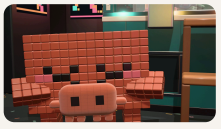
9.21 S
TRY 2: BONK



12.20 S
TRY 3: HOLDING ITS BREATH



14.75 S
THE SLOW CARRY



19.30 S
THE HUG, THE BLINK

THE FORMULA

01 A real physics pile

32 plush settle in a deterministic cannon-es bake. The claw is a kinematic body that shoves its neighbours, and every landing squashes the plush that lands.

02 Prongs stop on contact

Every physics step, each prong closes only until its box touches the prize, and the prongs open wide before they let go.

03 Zero clipping, measured

A per-frame intersection test over every plush, prong, coin, the hero and the cabinet. Fixed until it logged nothing on all 1200 frames.

04 Glass that acts

A real reflection on both sides of the front pane, a tint that flexes on the bonk, and a fog smudge where the forehead hit.

05 Acting with a plan

Eyes lead every move, a take and a double take on every gag, one held breath before the big moment, one look into the lens.

06 Measure, don't guess

Orange measured on the final frames, the camera path tested against the geometry, every hit checked against its frame.

PAGE 02

The prompt, copy-ready, block by block.

PAGE 03

Every follow-up, word for word, in order.

PAGE 04

Make it yours, render it smooth, every beat on its frame.

PAGE 05

Sound, its prompt and all 3 follow-ups.

The prompt

COPY-READY

280 WORDS

Paste it as is into Claude Code running Opus 5.5 at effort high. It writes one HTML file that plays in Chrome and renders frame by frame.

```
BRAND
HERO: 20x13 pixel mascot D97757: body 14x10 at (3,0), arms 3x2 at (0,5) and (17,5), legs 2x3 at x 4, 7, 11, 14
on row 10, eyes 0F0F0F 2x3 at (6,3) and (12,3)
PRIZES: 32 pillowy plush HEROs, felt eyes, some with a bow or beanie, one orange
MACHINE: teal cabinet 1F6F6B, cream trim, chrome 3-prong claw, bulb frame, MARQUEE "CLAW"
VENUE: night arcade, glowing cabinets
PALETTE: D97757, F3E6CF, 8DBFAF, F2C14E, E8A6B4, 7FA7D9
TRIES: 3 coins: drop, slip, win

One HTML file, three.js 0.160.0 + cannon-es, 1920x1080, 60 fps, 20 s. renderAt(t) samples a seeded physics bake.

LOOK: glass with a real reflection, warm LED strip inside, bokeh from real lights, neutral key so HERO reads
D97757.

BEATS (s):
0 HOOK: close on HERO's determined face at the glass, claw swinging; coin in, bulbs chase awake
1 try 1: eyes track the claw, HERO mimes the grab; the plush lifts, drops; shoulders sag, huff
4.6 coin 2, squint; HERO leans with the claw; the plush slips onto the chute edge, teeters, tumbles back; HERO
leans in: BONK on the glass, flex, fog smudge, dazed blink, rubs forehead
10 last coin, heartbeat music, tiny nudges; stillness, cheeks puffed; slow grab, sway, carry
15.6 THUNK; breath out; take, double take; hop down, victory wiggle, one look at us
17 pulls the plush from the flap, hugs it, eyes shut, blush, rocking; the plush slowly blinks at us; hold

CAMERA: one move: pull back from the hook, through the glass for the claw, inside the machine for the bonk, top-
down into the pile, slow macro carry, low on the drop, warm medium hug.

CHECKS: plush squash, claw pendulum, no clipping, eyes lead.
```

BRAND	**The block you swap.** The hero, the prizes, the machine with its marquee, the venue, the palette and how each try fails. The rest of the prompt only uses these names.
FORMAT	One HTML file with a physics bake at load, so every frame is a pure function of time and can be drawn at any rate.
LOOK	Night arcade, but bright enough for a phone: the machine is the light source, the bokeh comes from real cabinets, and a neutral key keeps the hero on brand.
BEATS	Three tries in seconds, each failing a different way, the bonk gag, the held breath, the win and the hug.
CAMERA	One continuous move with a job at every beat: from the hook through the glass, inside the machine for the bonk, top-down, macro, low, then the hug.
CHECKS	The physics and acting rules that make it feel real and alive.

Every follow-up I sent

7 ROUNDS

After each look at the stills, the strips, the intersection log or a measurement I wrote what I saw and what I wanted next. Word for word, in order. The first build came from the prompt alone.

FOLLOW-UP 1 / AFTER THE FIRST PHYSICS RUN AND THE FIRST STILLS

The pile is a mess: the plush spawn inside each other and fly out of the machine, two of them fall into the chute while the pile settles, and the three story plush end up face down or knocked over before their try. Spawn the plush spread out in one staggered layer, keep the chute closed while the pile settles, and drop the three story plush face up on top of the settled pile. The claw drags through the pile when it travels: travel higher and swing less. The prongs come down on the plush instead of around it: make them longer and open them wider. When the claw carries a plush, aim the stop so the plush, not the claw, ends over the chute. The pile hides HERO's face from inside the machine: make the plush smaller (0.36 per pixel) and keep the strip of floor in front of the face clear.

FOLLOW-UP 2 / AFTER THE FIRST FULL-TIMELINE CONTACT SHEET

The hook doesn't show the claw: let it hang lower at home so it swings right next to HERO's face, then rise before it travels. Try 2's plush tumbles back right in front of HERO's face and hides it: let it teeter on the chute's back rail and fall back into the pile. Frame the teeter and the bonk wider from the right so the plush on the rail and HERO's face are both in the shot. The fog smudge is a glowing white band: make it a small, faint patch. The hug camera is too close and too dark: pull back to a warm medium with the glowing machine behind, and wrap the arms further round the plush.

FOLLOW-UP 3 / AFTER THE FIRST INTERSECTION LOG (qa/clip_r1_merged.txt: 76 penetrating pairs)

Add a per-frame intersection test for every solid part (HERO's body, arms and legs, every plush's body, arms, legs and accessory, every prong, the joystick, button, coin box, coins, stool, flap, cabinet, chute and glass) and fix until it logs nothing: things may touch, never sink in. The prongs must stop on the plush while they close, every frame, and open wide before they let go, so a falling plush never slides through them. HERO's arms sink into the joystick, the button and the coin box: lower the controls so the stubby arms rest on top of them and lift an arm whenever it would sink in. Its feet sink into the stool when it rolls or leans: lift it onto the lower foot. The victory hop twirls through the glass: jump out away from the machine first. Behind the flap there is solid cabinet: hollow out the chute shaft and the bin, widen the flap so the plush fits through, and let the flap swing fully up. HERO grabs nothing: hold the plush at the tip of its arm, step well back from the machine before turning round, then slide the plush into the hug.

FOLLOW-UP 4 / AFTER MEASURING THE ORANGE AND THE SECOND CONTACT SHEET

HERO measures C6775D inside the machine and E58B68 / EB886A in the lit shots, salmon instead of D97757: calibrate its albedo (linear 0.83, 0.65, 0.60). The tight shot on the held breath is cut off by the move to the top-down view: hold it until the stillness ends, then crane up. The look into the lens is too close: pull back to 32 degrees. Outside, frame the flap from the front-left so we see the plush come out, and end on a slow push into the hug.

FOLLOW-UP 5 / AFTER THE FIRST FULL RENDER (qa/contact24.png, qa/strips_*.png of render 1)

A yellow plush sits right in front of HERO's face in nearly every inside shot and hides its mouth, even in the held-breath close-up: keep the floor in front of the face clear while the pile settles. The teeter happens at the very edge of the frame and the bonk is seen from the side: frame the back rail and HERO's face together, then push in for the bonk. The try-3 carry passes so close to the lens that the orange plush fills the frame and a chrome prong smears into a rainbow streak at 14.8 s: pull the macro back, raise the bloom threshold and dim the chrome's brightest reflection. Outside, film the flap from the right so the arm going in and the plush coming out are visible.

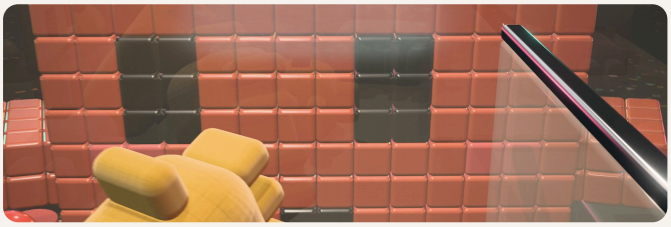
FOLLOW-UP 6 / AFTER THE NEW KEY STILLS

Front plush still cover HERO's mouth when it looks in: raise its step stool and the controls 2.5 units so the whole face sits above the pile, and lift the inside cameras with it. Frame 0 has a prong across HERO's eye: move the opening camera right so the face sits left and the swinging claw sits beside it, not over it. Outside, look down over the stool at the flap so the arm going in and the plush coming out are both visible.

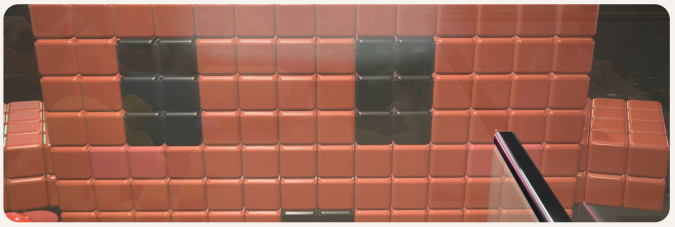
FOLLOW-UP 7 / AFTER THE SECOND FULL RENDER

On the way out through the glass the camera skims the coin box and loses HERO: rise higher, follow its twirl and land with it. The victory wiggle stops dead at 18.3 s and pops into the hug: ease it in and out. The plush's blink is too small to read on a phone: end on a slow push into the hug, low enough to keep the plush's face in frame.

FOLLOW-UPS 5 AND 6 IN ONE PICTURE, THE FACE ABOVE THE PILE



Before: at 12.2 s a plush in front of the glass hides the held breath.



After: the floor in front of the face is clear and the stool sits higher.

Make it yours

Only the BRAND block changes. Your character, your prizes, your machine: same three tries.

```
BRAND
HERO: your mascot as a pixel grid, its hex colors
PRIZES: 28 squishy plush frogs 7CC37A, felt eyes, a few in tiny crowns, one golden F2C14E
MACHINE: candy-pink cabinet E86A92, white trim, brass 4-prong claw, bulb frame, MARQUEE "GRAB"
VENUE: rainy-day mall corner, neon shopfronts
PALETTE: 7CC37A, F2C14E, FFF4E0, 5BB8D9, E86A92
TRIES: 3 tokens: misses, snags on the rail, wins
```

Render it smooth

1. Open the file with ?t= so it stops playing and only draws the time you ask for. The physics bake runs once at load.
2. Capture every frame at 2x (3840 x 2160) in headless Chrome on the GPU.
3. Inside each frame, average 12 samples in float, linear light: a time inside a 0.45-frame shutter, a point on the lens and a sub-pixel offset, so motion blur, depth of field and anti-aliasing come from one pass.
4. Tone map, Lanczos-downsample to 1920 x 1080 in linear light, add a little grain and dither.
5. Pipe raw frames into ffmpeg in lossless chunks, encode H.264 High at 60 fps, 25 Mbps, and mux the WAV as AAC.

Every beat on its frame

Checked on the rendered frames at 60 fps. Each sound peaks 1 frame (17 ms) after its picture, so it reads as caused by it.

TIME	FRAME	PICTURE	SOUND
0.00 to 0.30 s	f0 to f18	close on the determined face, the claw swinging; coin into the slot	coin clink
0.30 to 1.20 s	f18 to f72	the bulbs chase awake, its eyes go wide	wake jingle, arcade room tone
1.20 to 2.42 s	f72 to f145	joystick: the gantry glides, the claw swings	microswitch clicks, motor whine
2.42 to 3.40 s	f145 to f204	button; the claw drops and closes, the mascot mimes the grab	arcade button, cable ratchet, prong clack
3.42 to 4.52 s	f205 to f271	lifts, slips, falls back on the pile; shoulders sag, huff	soft thump, womp sting, huff
4.62 to 6.22 s	f277 to f373	coin 2, determined squint, steers to the second plush	clink, chime, clicks, button
6.28 to 8.46 s	f377 to f508	grab, lift, carry; the mascot leans with it	ratchet, clack, motor whine
8.56 to 9.20 s	f514 to f552	it slips onto the chute rail, teeters, tumbles back	opening clack, soft thumps
9.20 to 10.05 s	f552 to f603	BONK on the glass: flex, fog smudge, dazed blink, rub	thud with a glass ring, boing, wobble
10.05 to 12.48 s	f603 to f749	the last coin, tiny nudges, then a held breath	heartbeat and ticking, then only the heartbeat
12.52 to 15.60 s	f751 to f936	slow drop, grab, sway, careful carry	button, ratchet, clack, motor
15.70 to 16.18 s	f942 to f971	the prize falls through the chute: THUNK, breath out	deep thunk, win jingle, chase arpeggio
16.25 to 17.00 s	f975 to f1020	double take, one look at us, victory hop	whoosh, little landing
17.05 to 20.00 s	f1023 to f1200	pulls the plush from the flap, hugs it, blushes; the plush blinks at us	flap clack, squeak, shimmer, tink

3 TIPS

1

Script the drama, simulate the rest

The teeter on the rail is a shaped keyframe; the moment it tips, physics takes over.

2

Aim at the prize, not the claw

Re-aim the gantry when it grips, so the plush, not the hub, ends over the chute.

3

Film the face from inside

A hero facing a machine only shows its face through the glass: put the camera in the machine.

Sound

COPY-READY

248 WORDS

The picture is silent code; the sound came from one more prompt. Every sound is synthesized with the Web Audio API, no samples, each hit lands 1 frame after its picture. Gain and the limiter were applied in numpy after Web Audio.

```
SOUND: Web Audio API in an OfflineAudioContext, synthesized only, no samples, no voices or words, 48 kHz stereo WAV. Every hit peaks one frame after its picture event, driven by the same timeline and the physics bake.

ROOM: soft arcade room tone, a low hum and far-off blips.

MACHINE: a bright coin clink into the slot, then an original wake jingle as the bulbs chase. Joystick microswitch clicks, a chunky arcade button. The gantry motor whines with the gantry's speed, with a Doppler-ish bend; the cable unwinds with a light ratchet; the prongs close with a mechanical clack and open with a softer one.

PLUSH: every landing from the physics bake is a soft felt thump, bigger ones lower.

TRIES: a cheeky chiptune loop under tries 1 and 2. Try 1 ends in a sad "womp" sting and a tiny huff. Try 2: the BONK is a dull thud with a faint glass ring and a funny boing, then a wobbly dazed tone. Try 3: the music drops to a heartbeat pulse and a ticking clock, everything holds its breath; the prize lands with a deep THUNK.

WIN: a bright win jingle and a light-chase arpeggio, a whoosh for the victory hop and a little landing, a flap clack, a squeaky plush squeeze during the hug, a warm blush shimmer and one tiny "tink" on the plush's slow blink.

MIX: about -14 LUFS integrated, true peak at or under -2 dBTP, limiter never taking more than 3 dB.
```

Every sound follow-up I sent

SOUND FOLLOW-UP 1 / AFTER THE FIRST MIX

```
The bed is too quiet and the hits too hot: bring the music up 6 dB, the room tone up 10 dB, the foley up 1 dB; take the THUNK down 5 dB, the bonk down 6 dB, the coin clink, button and prong clack down 3-4 dB, and the heartbeat down 7 dB so it pulses instead of punching. Then normalize to -14 LUFS with a lookahead limiter at -3.0 dBTP that never takes more than 3 dB.
```

SOUND FOLLOW-UP 2 / AFTER MEASURING THE FINAL AAC

```
The AAC measures -1.9 dBTP, over the -2 dBTP limit: limit the WAV at -3.4 dBTP.
```

SOUND FOLLOW-UP 3 / AFTER THE LIMITER REPORT

```
The limiter still takes 5.4 dB: every hit sits 14 dB over the bed. Lift the music another 3 dB and the room tone 4 dB, pull the fx and foley down 2-3 dB, the cable ratchet and gantry whine down 3 dB, the heartbeat down 3 dB and the hop landing down 3 dB, then master again.
```

Result: -27.1 LUFS raw; normalised -14.0 LUFS, true peak -3.3 dBTP on the WAV, max limiter gain reduction 2.98 dB (gain and limiter applied in numpy).

Into the MP4: the WAV was muxed in as the video's AAC track with ffmpeg; the same step works for your own video.